Live Transcriber

User manual

Version 1.0.1 · 2026-11-01

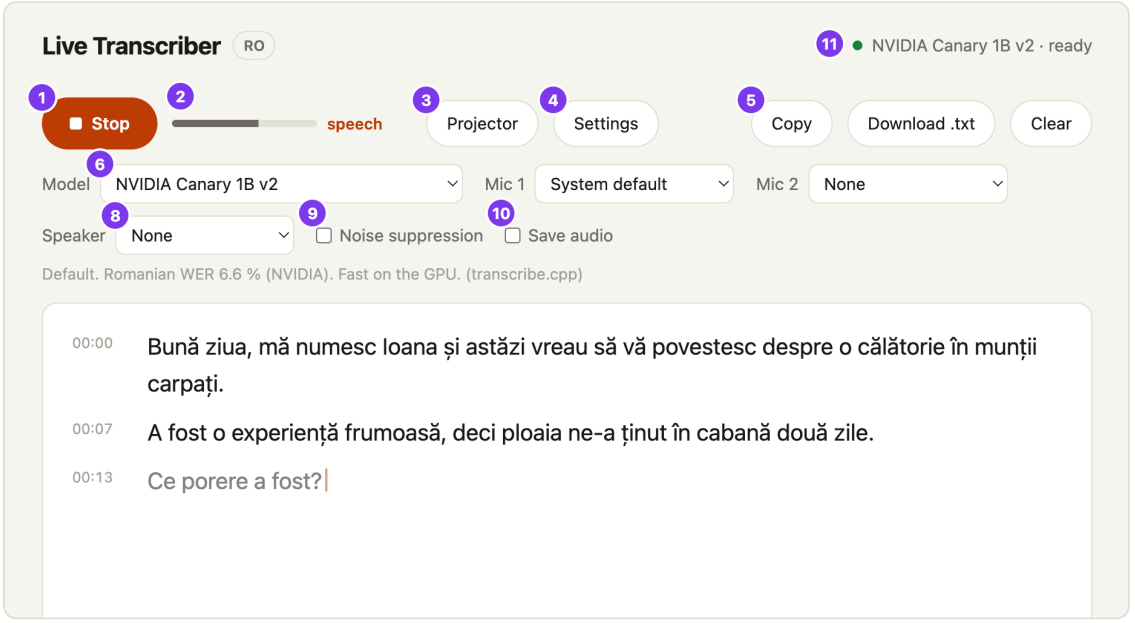
Live Transcriber turns Romanian speech into text while people talk. Everything runs on your own computer: no account, no internet after the first start, and the audio never leaves the machine, except with an optional cloud model (section 8).

1 Install and first start

1. **Download** the installer from github.com/Denis-Feier/local-word-transcriptor/releases, under **Assets**:
   - Mac with an Apple processor (M1 or newer), macOS 12 or newer: the file ending in `-mac-arm64.dmg`
   - Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit: the file ending in `-windows-setup.exe`
2. **Install.** Mac: open the `.dmg` and drag *Live Transcriber* into *Applications*. Windows: run the installer.
3. **Open it the first time.** The app is not digitally signed yet, so the system warns once. Mac: open the app, close the message, then go to *System Settings* → *Privacy & Security* and click *Open Anyway* (on macOS 14 or older, right-click the app → *Open*). Windows: at "Windows protected your PC" click *More info*, then *Run anyway*.
4. **Allow the microphone** when the Mac asks.
5. **Wait for the model.** The first time, the app downloads the Romanian speech model (1.1 GB) and shows the progress at the top right. After that it works without internet.

2 Transcribing a conversation

Press **Start** and talk. **Grey text** with a blinking cursor is the live guess while someone speaks. After a short pause (about 0.7 s) the sentence is written again in full and turns **black**: that is the final text, and it is saved straight away. Press **Stop** when you are done.



Recording with one microphone: two final sentences and a grey live guess underneath.

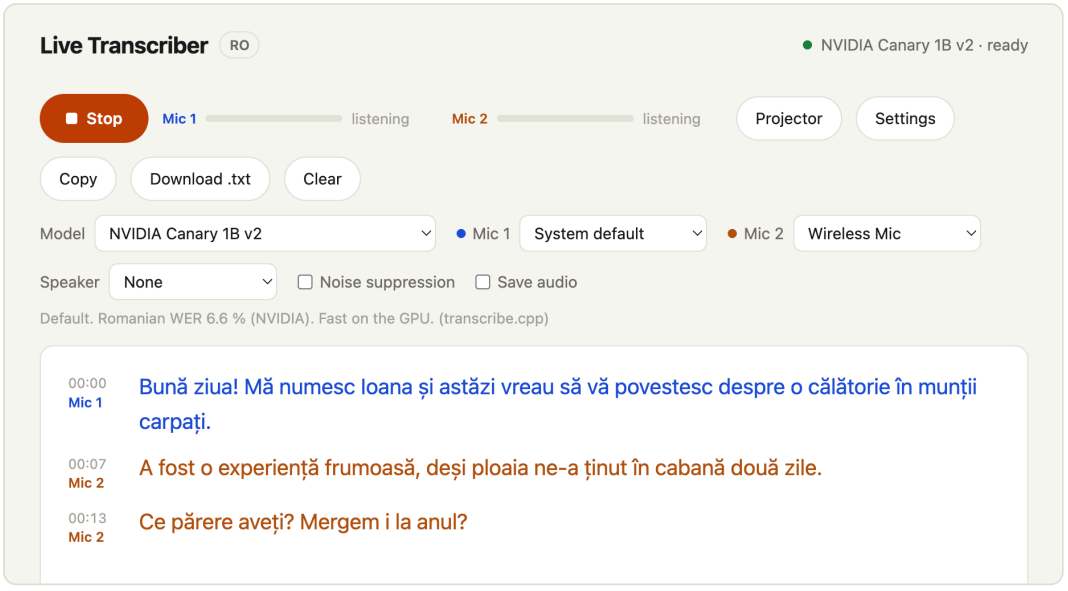
1 **Start** / **Stop**: starts and stops listening.

2. **Level meter**: moves with the sound the mic hears and says *speech* while someone talks. If it barely moves, the mic is too far away.
3. **Projector**: large captions for a projector or TV (section 5).
4. **Settings**: speech detection and the projector display (section 6).
5. **Copy**, **Download .txt**, **Clear**: copy the text, save a copy with times, or empty the screen and start a new transcript file.
6. **Model**: the speech model. Keep the default (section 8).
7. **Mic 1**, **Mic 2**: which microphones listen. *System default* is the computer's own. A second person can get a second mic (section 3).
8. **Speaker**: plays the voices on a speaker in the room (section 4). *None* is off.
9. **Noise suppression**: filters steady noise such as air conditioning or traffic. Off by default, because it can also swallow quiet, distant voices.
10. **Save audio**: also keeps the recording as a sound file next to the transcript (about 115 MB per hour and mic).
11. **Status**: the model in use and *ready*; on the first start, the download progress.

Transcripts are saved in **Documents** → **Live Transcriber** (menu *File* → *Open transcripts folder*). **Stop** and **Start** continue the same file; **Clear** starts a new one. Your choice of microphones and model is remembered for next time.

3 Two people, two microphones

For an interview, a doctor and a patient, or a panel of two, give each person their own microphone, close to them, and choose the second one under **Mic 2**. Any microphone the computer sees works: built-in, USB, jack, Bluetooth, or the receiver of a wireless kit.

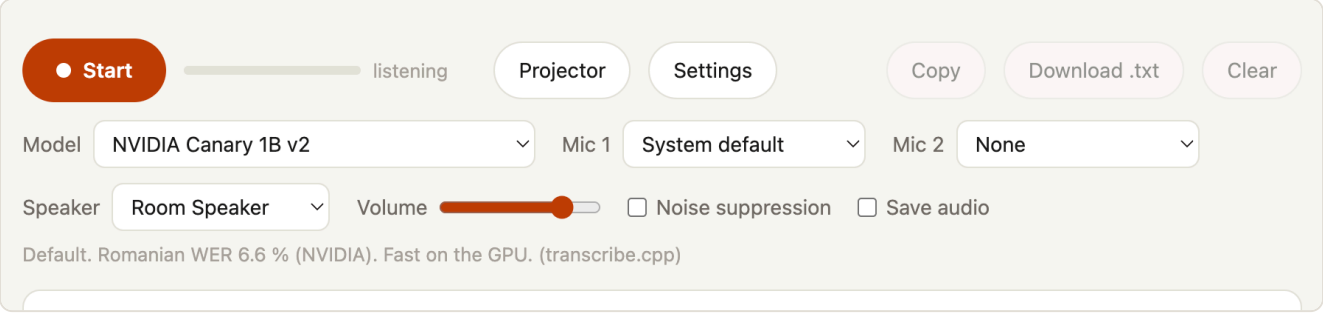


Each line shows the microphone that heard it, in that microphone's colour.

- Every line says who heard it: **Mic 1** blue, **Mic 2** orange, also in the projector view and as `Mic 1:` / `Mic 2:` in the saved file. Lines spoken at the same time are marked ⇄.
- Each mic also hears the other person, only more quietly. The app keeps those words only under the mic that heard them best. If they still show up under the wrong mic, see **Mic separation** in section 7.
- A mic that disconnects (Bluetooth out of range, flat battery, cable) shows *not connected*. The other mic keeps recording, and the first one joins again by itself once it is back.

4 Playing the voices on a speaker

If the audience needs to hear the people talking, connect a speaker and choose it under **Speaker**. It plays straight away, even before **Start**, so you can do a sound check: talk and watch the meter. **Start** and **Stop** don't affect it; *None* turns it off. The app always opens with *None*, so it never starts howling by surprise. **Volume** is remembered.



A speaker chosen before Start: the volume slider appears and the meter moves.

- **Prefer a cable or USB speaker.** Bluetooth speakers play about 0.2 s late, and the person talking hears that as an echo.
- **Howling** means a microphone hears the speaker. Put the speaker in front of the mics, facing away from them towards the audience, and turn **Volume** down. A laptop's own speakers almost always howl with its built-in mic.
- With two mics, keep the speaker away from both, or some lines may appear under the wrong mic.
- A Bluetooth speaker with its own microphone (many karaoke speakers): choose your real mics under **Mic 1** and **Mic 2** instead of *System default*, or the computer may record from the speaker's microphone and both the sound and the text get worse.
- A speaker that disconnects shows *not connected* and goes silent; the sound does not jump to the laptop. It plays again once it is back.

5 Captions on a projector or TV

Press **Projector** (or P): the window fills with large captions, the newest sentence brightest. Move the mouse to show the controls; they hide again after a few seconds, so the audience sees only text. The light in the bottom-left corner shows the microphone: grey off, green listening, orange someone speaking.

Key	In the projector view
+ −	text size
L	how many sentences are shown (1–5)
T	colours: white on black, yellow on black, black on white
F, double-click	full screen
Esc	back to the transcript



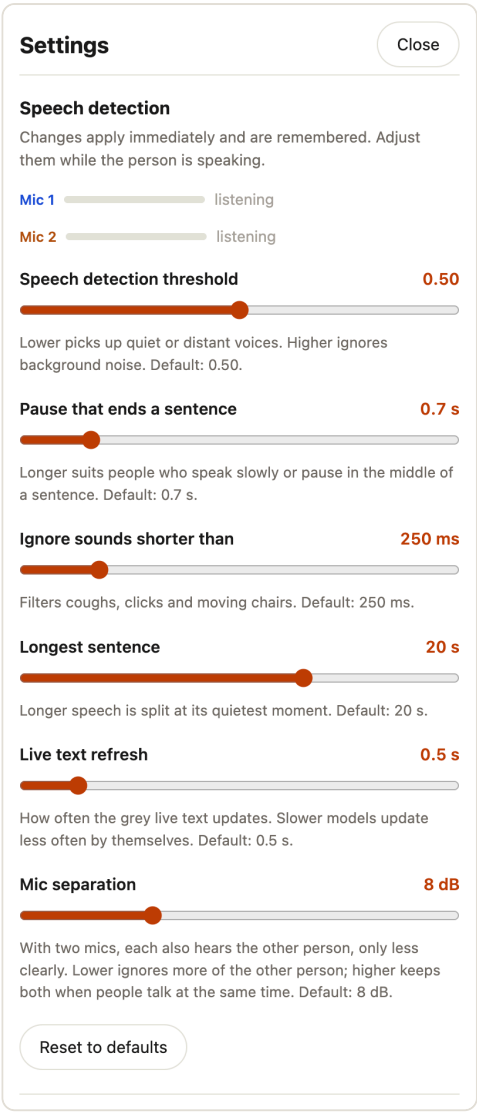
Projector as a second screen (not mirrored): open **Settings** → **Open caption window**. It opens on the projector, full screen; if it doesn't, drag it there and press F. It shows only the captions, while your window

keeps all the controls out of the audience's sight. **Text size**, **Sentences shown** and **Colours** are also in Settings, under *Projector display*.

6 Settings for speech detection

The defaults suit most rooms. If something goes wrong, change **one setting at a time while someone is talking**, and watch the text. Changes apply immediately and are remembered. A dot ● marks a changed setting; **Reset to defaults** undoes them all.

Setting	What it does
Speech detection threshold default 0.50	How sure the app must be that a sound is speech. Lower catches quiet or distant voices; higher ignores background noise.
Pause that ends a sentence default 0.7 s	The silence that closes a sentence. Longer suits people who speak slowly or pause mid-sentence.
Ignore sounds shorter than default 250 ms	Drops coughs, clicks and moving chairs.
Longest sentence default 20 s	Longer speech is split at its quietest moment.
Live text refresh default 0.5 s	How often the grey live text updates.
Mic separation default 8 dB	Only with two mics. Lower ignores more of the other person; higher keeps both when people talk at the same time.



7 Adjusting for different speakers and rooms

Find what you see, make the change, and check it while the person talks.

What you see	What to do
A quiet, soft-spoken or distant person is missed; the meter barely moves	Move the mic closer or give them their own. Then lower **Speech detection threshold** to 0.35–0.40.
Background noise (air conditioning, traffic, chatter) turns into stray words	Raise **Speech detection threshold** to 0.6–0.7. For steady noise, also tick **Noise suppression**.
A slow speaker, or one who stops to think, gets sentences cut in two	**Pause that ends a sentence**: 1.2–2 s.
A fast speaker who never pauses fills the screen with one huge line	**Longest sentence**: 10–15 s.

Quick back-and-forth on one mic: two people's words end up in one line	**Pause that ends a sentence**: 0.5 s, or one mic per person.
Coughs, clicks or moving chairs turn into words	**Ignore sounds shorter than**: 300–400 ms.
Very short answers (“Da.”, “Nu.”) are lost	**Ignore sounds shorter than**: 150 ms.
Two mics: one person's words also appear under the other mic	**Mic separation**: 5 dB, and move the mics further apart.
Two mics: when both talk at once, one of them is lost	**Mic separation**: 12 dB.
A presenter who walks around	A wireless clip-on mic as **Mic 1**.
Two Bluetooth headsets: one of them shows *no sound*	A Mac takes sound from only one Bluetooth headset mic at a time. Connect the other one through its USB receiver or a cable.
A group around a table	The laptop in the middle, screen up. For a long table, a USB conference mic.
Text appears late on an older computer	**Model**: *Parakeet Romanian 110M* (section 8), and **Live text refresh**: 1 s.
Strong accents, dialect, mumbling	No setting fixes these; a microphone close to the mouth helps most.

8 Choosing a model

Keep *NVIDIA Canary 1B v2*, the default and the most accurate. If text appears slowly on an older computer, choose *Parakeet Romanian 110M*: it is much faster, but writes in lowercase without punctuation. The other models in the list are alternatives to try. Models not downloaded yet show their size; choosing one asks first, downloads it and switches to it when it is ready. The choice is remembered.

ElevenLabs Scribe v2 Realtime (cloud) appears in the list only once an ElevenLabs API key has been added (the project's GitHub page explains how). It is the only model that sends the speech over the internet, to ElevenLabs, which charges for each hour of speech. While it is chosen, the note at the bottom of the window turns orange and says so. Choose another model for anything that must stay on this computer.

9 When something goes wrong

Problem	What to do
Start does nothing, or “Microphone access was blocked”	Mac: *System Settings* → *Privacy & Security* → *Microphone*, turn on Live Transcriber. Windows: *Settings* → *Privacy & security* → *Microphone*, allow desktop apps. Then restart the app.
A mic or the speaker shows *not connected*	Plug it in, switch it on or pair it again. It joins again by itself.
A mic shows *no sound*	It is connected but sends only silence: it is muted, or it is a second Bluetooth headset (section 7).
The meter moves but no text appears	Check that the right mic is chosen; lower **Speech detection threshold**.

The speaker howls	See section 4.
“Could not save audio”	The disk is full or the drive was removed. The text is still saved; free some space, then untick and tick **Save audio** again.
With the ElevenLabs model: an error starting with “ElevenLabs:”	No internet, a wrong key, or no credits left on the ElevenLabs account; the message says which. Choose another model to carry on.
Anything else	Menu *Help → Open logs folder*, and send the file `server.log` with a short description on the project's GitHub page (*Issues*).

This manual is also in the app: menu *Help → User manual*.